# Lesson 37: Mixed Tenses in Writing

*English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan*

*Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 14 Expressing Meaning in Mixed Tenses.*

## In this lesson

Most real writing mixes present, past and future tenses. In this lesson you will learn six strategies for switching between tenses, and how time words signal each tense. You will practise with short texts about American history (the civil rights movement, Brown v. Board of Education and Clarence Earl Gideon), then write your own paragraph. This unit is a review of all the verb lessons, so it will help you in every academic paragraph you write. Begin with the Pretest in your lesson material before you read on.

## Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Use six strategies to switch verb tenses correctly in a paragraph.
- Match each verb tense with its time words and related expressions.
- Find the verbs and time expressions in a paragraph and explain each tense shift.
- Correct verb tense errors, using the time words and the context as a guide.
- Write a paragraph that moves clearly between past, present and future.

## Key language

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| tense shift | a change from one verb tense to another | My brother liked history in high school. … Now he is enjoying physics. |
| time words (time expressions) | words that show when an action happens | yesterday, since then, now, in the future |
| main verb | here: the verb (with its helping verbs) that shows the tense of a clause | has promised, meant, had gained |
| context | the ideas around a sentence that help you understand it | Pay attention to the context. |
| proofread | read your writing carefully to find and fix errors | Always proofread before submitting your writing. |
| cor·re·SPOND | match, fit | Think what verb form corresponds to this particular tense. |

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| clue | a hint or an idea to help others understand | There should be clear in-context clues to help the readers follow your thoughts. |
| a·NAL·o·gy | a comparison based on similarities | Seasons : Clothes = Time Words : Verb Tenses |
| postwar; baby boom | after the war; a time when many babies are born | The country enjoyed a postwar baby boom. |
| BUR·gla·ry | a crime of breaking into other people's house to steal things | He committed robbery, burglary, and other crimes. |
| rep·re·SENT | speak for a person and defend that person in court | The Court appointed a lawyer to represent him. |
| ap·PEAL | formally ask a higher court to review the case | He appealed to the Florida Supreme Court. |
| de·FEN·dant | a person who is charged with a crime and who appears in a court | Every defendant has a right to a lawyer. |

## Rules and explanations

### Six strategies for switching tenses

1. **Understand the individual tenses.** Know the differences between them. Review the earlier verb lessons when needed (Lessons 5, 24, 26, 29 and 34).
2. **Match verb tense changes with time expressions.** When you switch from present to past, or from future back to present, switch your time words too. To check, underline the verbs and highlight the time expressions.
3. **Match verb forms with verb tenses.** After you choose the tense, choose the form that belongs to it (for example, present perfect = have/has + past participle).
4. **Pay attention to the context.** Sometimes a time word is left out to make the ideas flow. Then the context must give clear clues.
5. **Imagine that you are the reader.** Read your writing out loud. Is the order of actions, or the flow of logic, clear?
6. **Proofread** before you submit. You will catch more errors than you expect.

### Time words decide the tense

The book's analogy: **Seasons : Clothes = Time Words : Verb Tenses.** The season decides your clothes (a T-shirt in summer, a coat in winter). In the same way, time words decide the tense: yesterday for past tenses, tomorrow for future tenses. There are exceptions, but they are rare. Use the table as a general guide, and always check the context too.

| Tense and form | Time words and related expressions |
|---|---|
| Simple present: am/is/are; work/works | always, usually, often, sometimes, rarely, never ...; every day, once a week, on Tuesdays ... |
| Present progressive: am/is/are working | now, right now, at the moment, at present ...; today, these days, nowadays, currently, this semester ... |
| Present perfect: have/has been; have/has worked | since, for, recently, lately, so far, to date, till now, in the past/last two weeks ...; already, before, just, never, yet ...; once, two times, many times ...; today, these days, this week ...; or no time words |
| Present perfect progressive: have/has been working | since, for, recently, lately, so far, to date, till now, in the past/last two weeks ...; today, these days, this week ...; or no time words |
| Simple past: was/were; worked | yesterday, last night, two years ago, in 2000 ...; always, often, never ...; every day, once a week ... |
| Past progressive: was/were working | at this time yesterday, at 9 am this morning, at that moment, at that time ...; when; while |
| Past perfect: had been; had worked | by then, by that time, by + a specific past time, by + a past time clause ...; when, until, as soon as, before, after ... |
| Simple future: will be, am/is/are going to be; will work, am/is/are going to work | later today, tomorrow, next week, in 2035 ...; soon, in the future, in the near future ... |

Some time words (always, every day, when) appear in more than one row. Then the context decides: "every day" + present for a habit now, + past for a habit in the past.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no present perfect, so learners often use the simple present or simple past with since and for ("I live here since 2015"). Use the present perfect: "I have lived here since 2015."

## Practice

**Pretest** (lesson material, 10 sentences about Amy's interests and study). Do it first. Compare the verb in each sentence (bold in the book) with the other option. If it is correct, choose "correct"; if not, choose the other answer.

**Exercise 1.** How many times does the verb tense change in each group? Which time words and related expressions go with each tense?

1. My brother liked history in high school. However, he fell in love with science when he started college. Now he is enjoying physics, chemistry, and ecology courses in addition to a world history class.
2. My friend Lucy was a history major in college and has been teaching world history in a local high school for the last four years. She always says that mankind's best teacher is its own past. I agree,

but I like to look ahead and imagine what the future will be like. (The book prints "the mankind's"; "mankind" takes no article.)

3. By the time the Internet was invented, students had learned history through books and movies. Since the Internet started, YouTube videos have become one of the popular means of learning.

**Exercise 2.** In your lesson material, read "The American Dream". Underline the main verbs and highlight the time expressions. Name the tense of each main verb, and say where the tense changes and why.

**Exercise 3.** "Activism in the U.S." Use the time expressions in bold to fill in the blanks with the correct tenses.

The United States has had (have) a long history of activists seeking social, political, economic, and other changes to America. American sociopolitical activism (1) _____ (become) especially prominent **during the 1950s**. The African American civil rights movement (2) _____ (lead) the way. Martin Luther King Jr. (3) _____ (be) one of the most well-known leaders **at that time**. **Since then**, the United States (4) _____ (remain) a land of nearly constant change to bring about American democracy. It (5) _____ (seem) likely that Americans (6) _____ (stay) enthusiastic activists **in the future**.

**Exercise 4.** In your lesson material, read "Brown v. Board of Education" and fill in the 13 blanks (the example "send" is not counted). The time expressions to guide you: nowadays, in the past, in the early 1950s, in 1951, in 1954, even to this day.

**Exercise 5.** In your lesson material, read "Clarence Earl Gideon". Find and correct ten more errors in verb tenses (not including the example "has (had)"). Use the time words and the context as your guide.

## Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me about a period of my life, for example my teenage years: what I did then, what I do now and what I will do next. Correct my tense shifts and time words."
- "Give me a short paragraph about history with ten verbs in brackets. I will choose each tense from the time words, then explain my choices."
- "Check my answers to Exercise 2 in the lesson material, 'The American Dream'."
- "Here is my paragraph for the writing task: [paste]. Underline my verbs, list my time words, and show me any tense shift that is not clear."

## Read aloud

Pause briefly after a time expression at the start of a sentence (/).

- My brother liked history in high school. However, he fell in love with science when he started college. Now / he is enjoying physics.
- My friend Lucy was a history major in college and has been teaching world history in a local high school for the last four years.
- By the time the Internet was invented, / students had learned history through books and movies.

- Since the Internet started, / YouTube videos have become one of the popular means of learning.
- In America nowadays, / families of different races and backgrounds send their sons and daughters to the same public schools.
- The United States has had a long history of activists seeking social, political, economic, and other changes to America.

## Writing task

Book Exercise 6. Choose one topic and write one or more paragraphs (at least 10 sentences in all). Use appropriate time words and verb tenses.

- A social justice issue in your native country or in the U.S.
- An important event in the history of your native country and its causes.
- An important event in world history and its effects.
- A worsening environmental issue, the reasons for it, and its possible solutions.
- A period of your life, for example, your teenage years.

Include at least two clear tense shifts (for example, past → present → future), each signaled by a time word. You may begin with NSNT free writing (Lesson 1), then revise and edit.

Self-editing checklist:

- Underline every main verb and highlight every time expression.
- Each tense matches its time words (in 1951 → past; since then → present perfect; in the future → future).
- Each verb form matches its tense (has remained, not "has remain").
- Where there is no time word, the context makes the time clear.
- Future time clauses use a present verb (when that time comes).
- Read it aloud as a reader: is the order of events clear?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

## Answer key

**Pretest** (book): 1. has just graduated: correct. 2. is majoring → majored (she has graduated). 3. has concentrated → concentrated (her first two years are finished). 4. no change → did not change. 5. decided: correct. 6. is doing → was doing. 7. accomplished → had accomplished (it happened before graduation day). 8. start → is starting (will start is also correct). 9. will establish → establishes (time clause). 10. will come → comes (time clause).

**Exercise 1** (if you count every verb)

1. One change: simple past (liked, fell, started; in high school, when he started college) → present progressive (is enjoying; Now).
2. Three changes: simple past (was; in college) → present perfect progressive (has been teaching; for the last four years) → simple present (says, is, agree, like; always) → simple future (will be; the future).
3. Three changes: simple past (was invented) → past perfect (had learned; By the time the Internet was invented) → simple past (started) → present perfect (have become; Since the Internet started).

**Exercise 2** (the 11 main verbs in order, with their time expressions)

- has promised: present perfect (For many generations)
- meant: simple past (in the 1950s)
- began (producing), started: simple past (no new time word: still the 1950s)
- decided, enjoyed: simple past (At the same time; after the Second World War)
- began (to move): simple past (Meanwhile)
- enjoyed: simple past (soon)
- made: simple past (no time word: the context)
- had gained: past perfect (by then)
- are (still) attracting: present progressive (Today; still)

The paragraph moves from a long period up to now (present perfect), to the 1950s (simple past), to a change completed by that time (past perfect, "by then"), and finally to today (present progressive).

**Exercise 3** (book)

1. became 2. led 3. was 4. has remained 5. seems 6. will stay / are going to stay

**Exercise 4** (book)

1. was 2. started 3. were 4. could 5. refused 6. had 7. filed 8. argued 9. was 10. decided 11. was 12. was 13. has been affecting ("has affected" is also correct)

**Exercise 5**

1. he break into → he broke into
2. he has no money → he had no money
3. He does not have an education → He did not have an education

4. nor does he have any legal training → nor did he have any legal training
5. he lose the case → he lost the case
6. the court not give him → the court had not given him (or: did not give him)
7. Clarence had received a new trial → Clarence received a new trial
8. the court send many people → the court sent (or: had sent) many people
9. some of them have been able to go home → some of them were able to go home
10. Since then, the U.S. courts allow → Since then, the U.S. courts have allowed (or: have been allowing)

(Not a tense error, but more natural: "He then asked for the help of the U.S. Supreme Court.")

## My notes